that another can be spared the glare of publicity, at least for now and possibly ever?

The publication of secret documents, without context or challenge, has a pernicious effect on the debate that follows. As Inkster, the former British spymaster now at the International Institute for Strategic Studies in London, points out:

> Not even the NSA knows for certain how much information Snowden actually stole. It is clear, however, that he could not possibly have read more than a fraction of this material. It is equally clear that he did not understand the significance of much of the material he did read and that the same was true for the newspapers that published it. The resulting confusion and misapprehensions that have taken hold within the media and shaped the public debate about the NSA's bulk collection activities have not been effectively challenged or rebutted by the US and UK governments for various reasons, chief among which has been a desire not to create a damaging precedent by responding to specific allegations regarding the activities of their intelligence agencies. [59]

As far as can be inferred from Greenwald's public statements (he declined to respond to my requests for comment), his main aim is to make a splash. Asked how he chooses which material to release, and which to withhold, he answered:

> We chose certain information we wouldn't disclose, eg what would help other states improve their surveillance, or anything that NSA has gathered about people (that would do the NSA's dirty work) or anything that would endanger the lives of innocent human beings. We want to publish in a way that will create the most powerful debate and greatest level of recognition.[60]